

The prodigiously talented Anahat Singh was blooded early into sports by her lawyer father and interior designer mother, who both played hockey. While she started out with badminton, she followed in her elder sister's footsteps and was a regular feature on the domestic squash circuit by eight. At age 14, Anahat was the youngest member of the Indian team at the 2022 Commonwealth Games. By then, she had won the U-11 British Junior Open and the U-15 US Junior Open. She represented the national side again at the 2022 Asian Games, picking up two bronze medals in the mixed doubles and team events. Last year was a breakthrough season—on the senior circuit, Anahat picked up her first PSA World Tour Bronze title by winning the Squash on Fire Open in the US. A few months later, she qualified for her maiden Senior World Championships. The World Junior Championships win came as a perfect finale to her junior career.

HER ADVICE

"Winning the World Juniors is a turning point in my career. As it is my last junior tournament, it is also a perfect transition from the junior circuit to the senior one. I would ask young sportswomen to just give their 100 per cent and enjoy every moment of whatever they are doing"

Behind Anahat's gentle demeanour are a mature temperament and a burning desire to excel at the topmost stage. Under the mentorship of Gregory Gaultier and Saurav Ghosal, she has developed the skills required to take on more experienced opponents. Her ultimate target for now: the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028, where squash makes its debut.

At the moment though, Anahat is focusing on the Asian Games in September. There's a lot at stake, with the gold medallist assured direct qualification for the Olympics. "If I win gold, I can spend the next two years training for the Olympics, rather than trying to qualify," she says. With the confidence she's riding on these days, the goal seems well within her grasp. ■

— Shail Desai